



Republic of the Philippines
BENGUET STATE UNIVERSITY
La Trinidad, Benguet 2601

DEBATE SOCIETY



CONSTITUTION

Article 1. THE ORGANIZATION

The name of the organization shall be The Debate Society. Herein, it shall be referred to as “The Society.”

Article 2. VISION AND MISSION

Section 1. *Mission.* – The Society envisions a vibrant, inclusive, and intellectually stimulating community where individuals from diverse backgrounds come together to engage in respectful discourse.

Section 2. *Vision.* – The Society is dedicated to fostering critical thinking, effective communication, and a spirit of intellectual curiosity.

Article 3. DECLARATION OF PRINCIPLES

Section 1. The Society shall uphold the transformative power of reasoned dialogue. It recognizes that civil and intellectual debate is not merely an exercise in rhetoric, but a lifelong discipline essential to the pursuit of truth, critical thought, and personal development.

Section 2. The Society shall promote and protect the principles of diversity and inclusion. It affirms the importance of integrating the contributions, presence, and perspectives of individuals from various backgrounds into the community, and shall actively advocate for awareness of these values among its members and the broader local community.

Section 3. The Society shall adhere to the principles of democratic leadership, discipline, cooperation, industry, brotherhood, and harmony among its constituents, and shall provide appropriate avenues for the development and application of such competencies.



Republic of the Philippines
BENGUET STATE UNIVERSITY
La Trinidad, Benguet 2601

DEBATE SOCIETY



Section 4. The Society shall recognize and uphold the vital ties among students, faculty, administration, and other sectors of the academic community within Benguet State University. It shall serve as a platform for the peaceful and intellectual discussion of issues, concerns, and institutional initiatives.

Section 5. The Society and its members shall uphold the highest standards of honesty, fairness, and ethical conduct. All actions undertaken in the name of the Society shall be guided by a shared sense of responsibility: to truth, to one another, and to the duties entrusted to each member.

Section 6. The Society shall promote an enduring appreciation of Filipino culture, heritage, and values. It shall advocate for a form of patriotism grounded in critical love, compassion, civic engagement, and social responsibility, and shall reject all expressions of exclusion, hostility, or prejudice.

Section 7. The Society shall cultivate a spirit of constructive and healthy competition among its members and constituent Houses. All competitions and contests shall be designed to inspire excellence, deepen commitment, and strengthen both individual character and collective bonds.

Section 8. The Society shall preserve its meaningful traditions while remaining open to innovation and reform. It affirms that institutional relevance requires adaptability, and that traditions must evolve in response to the changing needs of its members and the broader society.

Section 9. The Society shall regard membership not merely as a temporary affiliation, but as a continuous process of growth: intellectually, socially, and morally. It shall strive to form individuals who are articulate, principled, and prepared to lead both within and beyond the organization.

Section 10. The Society shall affirm that education is not solely the acquisition of knowledge, but also the cultivation of awareness, empathy, and agency. It shall serve as a platform for empowerment through discourse, recognizing that learning is a means to liberation, personally, socially, and morally.

Section 11. The Society shall uphold the responsible and ethical integration of emerging technologies, including artificial intelligence, into debate preparation, research, and administrative operations. The Society recognizes that technological advancement must serve the pursuit of truth and intellectual integrity, not circumvent them. All members and officers shall ensure that technological tools are employed transparently, with proper attribution, and in strict



Republic of the Philippines
BENGUET STATE UNIVERSITY
La Trinidad, Benguet 2601

DEBATE SOCIETY



compliance with academic standards, thereby safeguarding the authenticity of discourse and honoring the Pillar of Kabunian through responsible stewardship of knowledge. These technological practices shall be interpreted consistently with this Constitution and shall not infringe upon the intellectual property rights or academic freedoms guaranteed to members under Article 4.

Section 12. The Society shall integrate environmental sustainability into its procurement practices, event planning, and daily operations. Recognizing that intellectual discourse thrives within a healthy and resilient community, the Society shall prioritize eco-conscious resource allocation, minimize waste, and promote sustainable engagement with its physical and digital environments. This commitment to ecological responsibility shall be guided by the Pillar of Laon's emphasis on long-term stewardship and shall be harmonized with the Society's operational mandates without compromising its core mission or the rights of its members under Article 4.

Section 13. The Society shall prioritize the holistic well-being and mental health of its members in the design, scheduling, and execution of all activities and competitive engagements. Acknowledging that rigorous intellectual pursuit must be balanced with psychological resilience, the Society shall foster a supportive environment that normalizes rest, provides accessible wellness resources, and rejects cultures of burnout or excessive strain. This principle shall be applied in a manner that upholds the Pillar of Manama's dedication to human dignity and shall be construed in full alignment with the fundamental rights and protections afforded to members under Article 4.

Section 14. The Society shall establish and maintain a confidential, non-retaliatory mechanism for the reporting of misconduct, ethical violations, or administrative malfeasance. Any member who discloses information in good faith regarding breaches of the Constitution, financial irregularities, or threats to institutional integrity shall be protected from retaliation, intimidation, or adverse action. This safeguard shall ensure accountability while preserving the presumption of innocence and due process rights enshrined in Article 4, and shall be interpreted consistently with the Society's commitment to the Pillar of Bathala's foundational values of truth, transparency, and principled leadership.

Section 15. The Society shall cultivate a structured and meaningful relationship with its alumni, recognizing their enduring contributions to the organization's legacy and intellectual tradition. Formal alumni engagement shall be facilitated through advisory roles, mentorship programs, and institutional partnerships, provided that such involvement remains strictly consultative and does



Republic of the Philippines
BENGUET STATE UNIVERSITY
La Trinidad, Benguet 2601

DEBATE SOCIETY



not supersede the autonomous decision-making authority of current student officers, the High Council, or the House Councils. Alumni participation shall be governed by clear operational boundaries that preserve student-led governance while honoring the Pillar of Kabunian's legacy of continuous knowledge transmission, and shall be interpreted in full conformity with the constitutional framework established herein.

Article 4.

RIGHTS OF THE MEMBERS

Section 1. The right of all the members for freedom to express, freedom of speech, and freedom to peaceful assembly, not contrary to the Constitution and Policies of the Society and existing laws governing such rights, against the Society.

Section 2. The right of all members to file a candidacy or be appointed for the highest governing body of the Society or their respective House's governing body position as prescribed by the provisions of this Constitution.

Section 3. The right to exercise suffrage, ensuring their participation in choosing representatives and voicing opinions on Society's governance matters.

Section 4. The right of all members to petition the proper authorities through the organization for redress of grievances, and present views and opinions conducive to broad, sound, and healthy thinking of vital issues concerning the welfare of the students.

Section 5. The right of all members to information on matters of public concern shall be recognized. Access to official records, documents, and papers pertaining to official acts, transactions, or decisions, as well as to research data used as basis for policy development, shall be afforded by all members, subject to such limitations as may be provided by the Constitution and Policies of the Society.

Section 6. The right of every member to be informed of the rules and regulations governing him.

Section 7. No member shall be subjected to exploitation, involuntary servitude or cruel or unusual punishment by the highest governing body of the Society or their respective House's highest governing body.



Section 8. The right of all members to form, assist, and join school-based and non-school-based organizations, alliances, and federations for their integral development.

Section 9. The rights of all members to avail all the facilities and resources of the organization for school related activities within the school campus, subject to limitations as may be provided by their respective House's highest governing body or the highest governing body of the Society.

Section 10. No member shall be subject to punishments, sanctions, or fines, solely by reason of his political beliefs and aspirations.

Section 11. In all punishment prosecutions conducted by the High Council or High Tribunal, the accused shall be presumed innocent until the contrary is proved, and shall enjoy the right to be heard by himself and counsel, to be informed of the nature and cause of the accusation against him, to have a speedy, impartial, and public trial, to meet the witnesses face to face, and to have compulsory process to secure the attendance of witnesses and the production of evidence in his behalf. For clarity, the public trial and compulsory process requirements of this Section shall not apply to administrative hearings conducted by House Councils for Minor Violations under the Rules and Procedures, provided such hearings guarantee the Respondent's fundamental rights to written notice, to be heard, to present evidence, and to receive a written decision. However, after arraignment, the trial may proceed notwithstanding the absence of the accused, provided that he has been duly notified and his failure to appear is unjustifiable.

Section 12. No member shall be compelled to be a witness against himself.

Article 5.

MEMBERSHIP

- (1) The membership for the Society shall be open to all students of Benguet State University, regardless of their college, degree program, gender, class, race, political, religious, and/or other personal affiliations.
- (2) Admission into a House shall constitute Provisional Membership in the Society. To attain Full Membership status, all provisional members must complete a mandatory one (1) academic semester of service within an Office of the High Council as an Executive Intern.



- (a) Every admitted member of a House is required to be deployed to one of the Executive Offices of the High Council to assist the respective Secretaries in Society-wide operations.
 - (b) This service shall constitute a structured training curriculum designed to ensure every member understands and embodies the pillars of Manama, Bathala, Kabunian, and Laon before being conferred permanent status. The curriculum shall include defined competency modules covering parliamentary procedure, debate theory, ethical conduct, organizational management, and the Society's operational protocols. Each Executive Intern shall be paired with a designated Full Member mentor who shall provide guidance, performance feedback, and professional development support throughout the internship period. Progression to Full Membership status shall be contingent upon the successful completion of prescribed milestones, including:
 - (i) satisfactory completion of all competency modules as verified by the supervising High Council Secretary;
 - (ii) demonstrated proficiency in assigned operational tasks;
 - (iii) positive evaluation from the assigned mentor; and
 - (iv) submission of a reflective portfolio documenting growth and contribution to the Society.
 - (c) Upon the successful completion of the one(1) academic semester of service and a satisfactory performance rating from the supervising High Council Secretary, the individual shall be elevated to Full Member status.
 - (d) Executive Interns shall have the right to participate in House activities and debates; however, they shall be restricted from voting on High Council-level Constitutional amendments and from seeking elective office until their Full Membership is formally conferred.
- (3) Each House shall have the exclusive right to recruit, evaluate, and accept its own members in accordance with its internal membership policy, values, and traditions. Any eligible individual who seeks to become part of the Society may do so by applying directly to one of the four Houses. Admission into a House shall constitute formal



membership in the Society. However, all House recruitment must adhere to the following rules:

- (a) All membership applications shall be approved by a majority vote of the respective House Council.
- (b) No individual may be a member of more than one House at a time.
- (4) Each House shall maintain and publicly disclose its own Membership Policy, which must be aligned with the Society's Constitution and Policies, uphold the principles of fairness, transparency, and merit, and be reviewed and approved by the President, with the concurrence of the House Council, before implementation.
- (5) Transfers between Houses may only occur during official transfer periods and require the mutual consent of both Houses involved.
- (6) The membership shall be valid for one[1] academic year and shall be renewed for the following academic year. Renewal of membership to a House only requires the approval of the House Council and does not need the approval of the President.
- (7) Members shall abide by their respective House Charter, House policies, the Society Constitution, and the Society policies.
- (8) The High Council and the House Councils may sanction members for misconduct, based on collected evidence, inclusion policy, and prior warnings.
- (9) Alumni Associate Membership. Individuals who have attained Full Membership status and subsequently graduated from Benguet State University or otherwise departed the Society in good standing may apply for designation as an Alumni Associate. Alumni Associates shall retain advisory privileges, including the right to receive Society communications, attend open Society events as observers, and provide consultative input to House Councils or the High Council upon invitation. However, Alumni Associates shall not possess voting rights on any Society matter, shall not be eligible to hold elective or appointive office within the Society, and shall not participate in internal disciplinary proceedings except as witnesses or character references. The terms of Alumni Associate engagement shall be governed by policies established by the Council of House Chancellors and approved by the President, which shall ensure that student-led



Republic of the Philippines
BENGUET STATE UNIVERSITY
La Trinidad, Benguet 2601

DEBATE SOCIETY



governance remains paramount and that Alumni Associate involvement remains strictly consultative in nature.

- (10) Re-admission of Former Members. Individuals who previously held Full Membership status and departed the Society in good standing, as certified by the Office of Internal Affairs, may petition for re-admission to the Society. Such petitions shall be submitted in writing to the relevant House Council and shall include a statement of intent, evidence of prior good standing, and a commitment to abide by all current Society policies. Re-admission shall require: (a) approval by majority vote of the petitioning House Council; (b) verification of good standing by the Society Office of Internal Affairs; and (c) concurrence of the President. Re-admitted members shall be restored to Full Membership status without requirement to repeat the Executive Internship, provided their departure occurred no more than three(3) academic years prior to the petition. Re-admitted members shall retain all rights and privileges of Full Membership, subject to any amendments to the Constitution or Policies enacted during their period of absence.
- (11) Every member of the Society is required to pay a membership fee at the commencement of each semester. The specific amount of the fee shall be determined through a deliberation and majority vote of the Council of House Chancellors, subject to the final approval of the President.

Article 6.

THE SOCIETY HOUSES

Section 1. Declaration of the Society Houses

The Society shall be composed of four permanent and chartered Houses, each representing a unique philosophical, cultural, and symbolic identity that reflects the values of the Society. These Houses shall serve as the foundational sub-organizations of the Society and shall act as the primary units for competitive debate, truth-seeking, scholarly inquiry, community-building, and leadership development.

Section 2. Establishment.

- (1) There shall be four permanent Houses of the Society, established in honor of the four foundational student leaders who chartered the Debate Society. Each House shall also maintain its own motto, emblem, color, and values, subject to approval by the House



Republic of the Philippines
BENGUET STATE UNIVERSITY
La Trinidad, Benguet 2601

DEBATE SOCIETY



Society. Houses shall have autonomy over their membership policies, internal structure, traditions, and activities, so long as they remain consistent with the Constitution and Policies of the Society. These Houses shall be known as: House of Bathala, House of Laon, House of Manama, House of Kabunian.

- (2) A group of Society members may apply for the formal establishment of a new House by submitting a House Charter to the Council. The Charter must include, but shall not be limited to:
 - (a) The proposed House motto, emblem, and core values;
 - (b) The intended structure of its House Council;
 - (c) Its initial membership policy;
 - (d) A code of conduct and internal rules.
- (3) All House Charters must be in full accordance with the Constitution and policies of the Society. Any provisions inconsistent with Society principles shall be subject to revision or rejection.

Article 7.

THE HOUSE COUNCILS

Section 1. Declaration of the House Councils.

- (1) Each House shall be governed by a House Council, which shall serve as the highest governing body within the House. It shall have full authority over the internal affairs of the House, subject to the overarching Constitution and policies of the Society.
- (2) All official House policies, amendments, and internal rules shall be enacted through formal House Council Resolutions. A resolution shall require the concurrence of a majority of the sitting House Council members and the approval of the House Chancellor to be considered valid. Each resolution shall be properly documented, dated, and entered into the House Chronicle or Records.

Section 2. The functions of the House Council shall be:



Republic of the Philippines
BENGUET STATE UNIVERSITY
La Trinidad, Benguet 2601

DEBATE SOCIETY



- (1) Formulate and implement internal policies, plans, and initiatives consistent with the House Charter, serve as the supreme decision-making authority within the House, and uphold and promote the House's values, traditions, and identity;
- (2) Manage the recruitment, selection, and induction of new members in accordance with the approved House Membership Policy, monitor member participation, engagement, and standing within the House, recommend or implement probationary systems, mentorship programs, and similar member development efforts;
- (3) Organize and coordinate worthwhile student activities designed to improve the general welfare of the students, as well as to prepare them for constructive citizenship and to develop sound and critical thinking among members;
- (4) Represent the House in the Council of House Chancellors and in communications with the Society High Council, ensure the House is informed of Society-wide policies, deadlines, and events, and serve as the intermediary in matters requiring coordination between Houses;
- (5) Enforce the House's internal code of conduct and values, investigate and address minor violations or conflicts among House members, and recommend disciplinary action, including suspension or expulsion, subject to review by the High Council, through the Internal Affairs Office, for serious offenses;
- (6) Manage the House's treasury, prepare and maintain transparent financial records and submit them to the High Council, through the Finance and Resource Management Office, and ensure all expenditures serve the interests and mission of the House;
- (7) Maintain the integrity of the House's motto, emblem, color, and cultural identity, document important events, programs, and achievements in an official House chronicle or report, and promote a sense of pride, continuity, and historical awareness among members;
- (8) Regularly assess House operations and member satisfaction, submit semester reports on House performance, activities, and membership to the Society Secretariat Director and propose amendments to the House Charter, subject to the approval of the House members, with the concurrence of the President.



Republic of the Philippines
BENGUET STATE UNIVERSITY
La Trinidad, Benguet 2601

DEBATE SOCIETY



- (9) Execute specific mandates and duties as may be directed by the President, provided that such instructions are conducive to the general welfare and holistic development of the Houses, the Society, and the community at large.
- (10) **Mandatory Society Sustainability Levy.** Notwithstanding the treasury management authority granted under subsection (6), each House Council shall remit twenty percent (20%) of its unrestricted semester-end surplus funds to the Society General Fund as a mandatory Society Sustainability Levy. Such levy shall be administered by the Office of Financial and Resource Affairs (OFRA) and allocated exclusively for Society-wide operational reserves, emergency contingencies, and inter-House capacity building. The remaining eighty percent (80%) shall remain under the exclusive management of the respective House Council. Funds subject to external donor restrictions, university grants, or legally encumbered obligations shall be exempt from this levy. The High Council shall publish a semi-annual allocation report detailing how levy funds are utilized.

Section 3. The House Council shall be the primary governing body of the House, composed of officers duly elected or appointed to lead its various departments. The Council shall be organized into Executive Offices, each overseen by a Director. The composition of the House Council shall be determined through a formal House Council Resolution, approved by a majority of the Council and signed by the House Chancellor. While each House may establish additional or modified positions in accordance with its internal needs and traditions, the standard organizational structure shall consist of the following:

- (1) The Office of the House Chancellor.

The House Chancellor, who shall be elected by a direct vote from the House members, shall serve as the head of the House Council. The powers and duties of the House Chancellor shall be:

- (a) Presides over all House Council meetings and House Assemblies;
- (b) Approves House Council Resolutions;
- (c) Exercises executive oversight over House programs and governance;
- (d) Represents the House in official Society-wide assemblies and external affairs;



- (e) May veto any House Council Resolution, subject to override by a two-thirds vote; and
- (f) Shall be a member of the Council of House Chancellors.
- (g) Performs such other duties as may be assigned by the House Council or the President.
- (h) Conflict of Interest Recusal. Any officer of the House Council shall recuse themselves from deliberation, discussion, and voting on any matter in which they have a direct or indirect financial interest, a competitive advantage relative to other Houses or members, or a personal relationship that may reasonably be perceived to impair their impartiality. Specific scenarios requiring recusal shall include:
 - (i) matters involving procurement, contracting, or financial allocation where the officer or an immediate family member stands to gain materially;
 - (ii) disciplinary proceedings involving the officer, a close relative, or a member with whom the officer has a significant personal or professional relationship;
 - (iii) competitive evaluations, point allocations, or award determinations where the officer's House or affiliated members are direct beneficiaries; and
 - (iv) any matter where the officer has participated in prior unofficial consultations that may compromise objective judgment.

Prior to the commencement of any agenda item, officers shall formally disclose any potential conflict to the House Council, and such disclosure shall be recorded in the official minutes of the meeting. Failure to disclose a conflict of interest, or participation in a matter following a required recusal, shall constitute a Major Violation under Article VI of the Rules and Procedures and may result in sanctions including censure, suspension from voting privileges, or removal from office pursuant to disciplinary procedures. All recusal determinations shall be subject to review by the Society Office of Internal Affairs upon petition by any House member.



(2) The Office of the House Vice Chancellor.

The House Vice Chancellor shall serve as the second-in-rank of the House Council and shall be elected by a direct vote of the House membership. The powers and duties of the House Vice Chancellor shall be:

- (a) Assists and substitutes for the Chancellor in their absence;
- (b) Oversees coordination between officers and monitors internal execution;
- (c) Assists the House Chancellor in the preparation of reports for the Council of House Chancellors;
- (d) Performs such other duties as may be assigned by the House Chancellor or the House Council.

(3) The Office of the Secretariat.

The Secretariat Director shall be appointed by the House Chancellor. The Director shall lead the Office of the Secretariat and serve as the third-in-rank officer of the House Council. This OfficeThe powers and duties of the Secretariat Office shall be:

- (a) The primary custodian of all House records, responsible for the drafting of official documents, the recording of minutes for all House meetings and assemblies;
- (b) Shall maintain a systematic record of all House Council Resolutions and Policy Mandates, ensuring they are accessible to all members for reference;
- (c) Shall be responsible for the documentation of the House Chronicle, recording the achievements, major events, and historical milestones of the House during their term; and
- (d) Performs such other duties as may be assigned by the House Chancellor or the House Council.

(4) The Office of Internal Affairs



The Director of Internal Affairs shall be appointed by the respective House Chancellor. The Director shall lead the Office of Internal Affairs and serve as the primary officer responsible for the internal cohesion, discipline, and welfare of the House members. The powers and duties of the Internal Affairs Office shall be:

- (a) Enforce the House's internal code of conduct and values, ensuring that all members uphold the prestige and integrity of the Society;
- (b) Maintain the official House Membership Database, monitor the participation, engagement, and semesterly standing of each member;
- (c) Act as the primary mediator in internal disputes or conflicts among House members, fostering a culture of mutual respect and cooperation;
- (d) Monitor the general well-being of members and oversee the implementation of probationary systems, mentorship programs, and similar member-development efforts;
- (e) Propose, design, and implement programs and activities aimed at the holistic development of members;
- (f) Investigate minor violations of House policies and recommend formal disciplinary actions to the House Council, subject to the review of the Society's Internal Affairs Office;
- (g) Manage the recruitment and selection of new members in accordance with the approved House Membership Policy.
- (h) Performs such other duties as may be assigned by the House Chancellor or the House Council.

(5) The Office of External Affairs

The Director of External Affairs shall be appointed by the respective House Chancellor. The director shall lead the Office of External Affairs and serve as the primary liaison between the House and all entities beyond its internal membership. The powers and duties of the Director of External Affairs shall be:



Republic of the Philippines
BENGUET STATE UNIVERSITY
La Trinidad, Benguet 2601

DEBATE SOCIETY



- (a) Serve as the primary point of contact for coordination with other Houses, fostering a spirit of friendly rivalry and collaborative growth within the Society;
 - (b) Assist the House Chancellor in representing the House's interests before the Council of House Chancellors and the Society High Council;
 - (c) Propose and lead initiatives, programs, and partnerships that extend the House's impact to the community at large, aligning with the Society's mission of constructive citizenship;
 - (d) Identify and establish partnerships with external organizations, sponsors, or academic institutions that can provide resources, venues, or opportunities for the House;
 - (e) Lead the planning and execution of joint activities, inter-House competitions, and Society-wide events, ensuring the House's active and prestigious participation;
 - (f) Performs such other duties as may be assigned by the House Chancellor or the House Council.
- (6) The Office of Financial and Resource Affairs

The Director of Financial and Resource Affairs shall be appointed by the House Chancellor and shall lead the Office of Financial and Resource Affairs. This Office shall serve as the chief fiscal department and the quartermaster of the House. The powers and duties of the Financial and Resource Affairs Office shall be:

- (a) Act as the primary custodian of the House Treasury, ensuring the secure collection, management, and documentation of all funds, including membership dues and revenues;
- (b) Maintain a comprehensive and updated Inventory of House Assets; oversee the procurement, systematic storage, and maintenance of all physical equipment, supplies, and digital resources;
- (c) Develop the semesterly House Budget in coordination with the House Chancellor, ensuring the optimal allocation of resources toward the House's strategic goals;



Republic of the Philippines
BENGUET STATE UNIVERSITY
La Trinidad, Benguet 2601

DEBATE SOCIETY



- (d) Manage the distribution and retrieval of House properties for official events, ensuring all materials are functional, accounted for, and returned to storage;
- (e) Maintain a transparent and systematic ledger of all transactions; prepare and publish regular financial and resource audits for review by the House Council;
- (f) Conduct periodic assessments of the condition of House equipment and propose the acquisition or disposal of assets based on the House's operational needs;
- (g) Propose and implement programs focused on financial literacy, resource sustainability, and the optimization of House assets for the benefit of the general membership;
- (h) Performs such other duties as may be assigned by the House Chancellor or the House Council.

(7) The Office of Business Affairs

The Director of Business Affairs shall be appointed by the House Chancellor and shall lead the Office of Business Affairs. This Office shall serve as the primary revenue-generating and entrepreneurial wing of the House. The powers and duties of the Business Affairs Office shall be:

- (a) Conceptualize, propose, and spearhead Income-Generating Projects (IGPs) to ensure the financial sustainability and independence of the House;
- (b) Manage the production and sale of official House merchandise, ensuring that all products uphold the House's visual identity and prestige;
- (c) Identify and negotiate partnerships, sponsorships, or advertisements with external entities and local businesses to provide additional funding or resources for House projects;
- (d) Conduct surveys and research within the House and the wider Society to determine the demand for specific products, services, or events;
- (e) Prepare comprehensive business plans, project proposals, and post-activity financial statements for every IGP, ensuring all ventures are professional and transparent;



- (f) Propose and implement activities that develop the entrepreneurial skills of House members, such as business pitching competitions or financial modeling workshops;
- (g) Perform such other duties as may be assigned by the House Chancellor or the House Council.

(8) The Office of Public Affairs

The Director of Public Affairs shall be appointed by the House Chancellor and shall lead the Office of Public Affairs. This Office shall serve as the official media, branding, and information wing of the House. The powers and duties of the Public Affairs Office shall be:

- (a) Serve as the primary manager of all official House social media accounts, ensuring the timely posting of announcements, event updates, and member spotlights;
- (b) Lead the conceptualization and creation of all visual materials, including posters, infographics, digital layouts, and promotional videos, ensuring they meet the House's aesthetic standards;
- (c) Act as the custodian of the House's brand; ensure that all public-facing materials correctly use the official House logos, colors, and typography;
- (d) Act as the public information office for the House, ensuring that all members and the general public are well-informed of House activities, resolutions, and official stances;
- (e) Perform such other duties as may be assigned by the House Chancellor or the House Council.

Article 8. **THE HIGH COUNCIL**

Section 1. Declaration of the High Council.



Republic of the Philippines
BENGUET STATE UNIVERSITY
La Trinidad, Benguet 2601

DEBATE SOCIETY



The High Council shall be the highest governing body of the BSU Debate Society. It shall have jurisdiction over the Society Houses, including the House Councils, ensuring they adhere to the Society's policies.

Section 2. General Provisions of the High Council.

- (1) The High Council shall be composed of offices elected or appointed in accordance with the Constitution. The Council shall not be limited to the following offices: Office of the President, Office of the Vice President, Office of the Executive Secretary, Office of Internal Affairs, Office of External Affairs, Office of Business Affairs, Office of Finance and Resource Management, Office of Public Affairs. Each office shall be headed by a Secretary.
- (2) The President and Vice President shall be elected by a direct vote from the Society members. The Executive Secretary and the Secretary of a respective office shall be appointed by the President.
- (3) All members of the High Council must be a bona fide member of the Society and have at least one (1) semester of active participation in any House or committee of the Society.

The qualifications of the President shall include:

- (a) At the time of filing for candidacy, the individual must have served at least one (1) full term in any of the following Principal Officer capacities: As a Secretary or Vice President within the High Council; or As a House Chancellor, House Vice Chancellor, Director within a House Council;
- (b) Must demonstrate a mastery of the Society's Four Pillars: Manama, Bathala, Laon, and Kabunian;
- (c) Must not have been found guilty of any major disciplinary violations within the University or the Society;
- (d) Must have been a member of the Society for at least two (2) academic years, which includes the mandatory year served as a Provisional Member;
- (e) Must not have served as the President of the Society.

The qualifications of the Vice President shall include:

- (a) At the time of filing for candidacy, the individual must have served at least one (1) full term in any of the following Principal Officer capacities: As a Secretary within the High Council; or As a House Chancellor, House Vice Chancellor, Director within a House Council;



Republic of the Philippines
BENGUET STATE UNIVERSITY
La Trinidad, Benguet 2601

DEBATE SOCIETY



- (b) Must demonstrate a mastery of the Society's Four Pillars: Manama, Bathala, Laon, and Kabunian;
- (c) Must not have been found guilty of any major disciplinary violations within the University or the Society;
- (d) Must have been a member of the Society for at least two (2) academic years, which includes the mandatory year served as a Provisional Member.

The qualifications of the Executive Secretary shall include:

- (e) At the time of filing for candidacy, the individual must have served at least one (1) full term in as a member of the High Council or their respective House Council, not including their service as a Provisional Member;
- (f) Must demonstrate a mastery of the Society's Four Pillars: Manama, Bathala, Laon, and Kabunian;
- (g) Must not have been found guilty of any major disciplinary violations within the University or the Society;
- (h) Must have been a member of the Society for at least two (2) academic years, which includes the mandatory year served as a Provisional Member.

The qualifications of the Secretaries shall include:

- (a) Must have been a member of the Society for at least two (2) academic years which includes the mandatory year served as a Provisional Member;
 - (b) Must demonstrate a mastery of the Society's Four Pillars: Manama, Bathala, Laon, and Kabunian;
 - (c) Must not have been found guilty of any major disciplinary violations within the University or the Society;
- (4) If an elected or appointed member of the High Council is terminated, asked to resign, or impeached due to excessive absences or other grounds, then he or she shall not be able to be appointed or elected to the High Council for the remainder of that academic year.
- (5) Succession, Emergency Continuity, and Acting Appointments.



Republic of the Philippines
BENGUET STATE UNIVERSITY
La Trinidad, Benguet 2601

DEBATE SOCIETY



- (a) Vacancy Succession. In the event of a vacancy in any High Council office due to resignation, removal, impeachment, death, incapacity, or ineligibility, succession shall proceed as follows:
- (i) For the Office of the President: The Vice President shall immediately assume the duties and title of President for the remainder of the term.
 - (ii) For the Office of the Vice President: The President shall appoint a successor from among the sitting House Chancellors or High Council Secretaries, subject to confirmation by majority vote of the Council of House Chancellors within seven(7) calendar days.
 - (iii) For any High Council Secretary office: The President shall appoint an Acting Secretary from among qualified Full Members, who shall serve for a period not exceeding thirty(30) calendar days pending confirmation of a permanent appointee. Confirmation shall require approval by majority vote of the Council of House Chancellors.
 - (iv) All successors and appointees must meet the constitutional qualifications for the office they assume under Section 2(3) of this Article.
- (b) Emergency Quorum Procedures. In circumstances of institutional crisis, natural disaster, public health emergency, or other extraordinary conditions that prevent physical convening of the High Council, an "Emergency Quorum" may be established. An Emergency Quorum shall consist of at least fifty percent(50%) of sitting High Council officers participating via secure virtual platform, provided that:
- (i) the President or Vice President has issued a formal declaration of emergency;
 - (ii) all participating members are verified as present through authenticated digital means;
 - (iii) deliberations and votes are recorded and archived in accordance with Article VIII of these Rules and Procedures; and



Republic of the Philippines
BENGUET STATE UNIVERSITY
La Trinidad, Benguet 2601

DEBATE SOCIETY



- (iv) any action taken under Emergency Quorum shall be ratified by a physical quorum within fourteen(14) calendar days of the restoration of normal convening capacity, failing which such action shall be deemed null and void.
- (c) Acting Officer Appointments. The President may designate an "Acting Officer" to temporarily discharge the duties of any vacant or incapacitated High Council office, provided that:
 - (i) the appointment is limited to a period not exceeding thirty(30) calendar days;
 - (ii) the Acting Officer meets the constitutional qualifications for the office;
 - (iii) the appointment is documented in writing and communicated to the Council of House Chancellors within twenty-four(24) hours; and
 - (iv) a permanent appointment or election to fill the vacancy is initiated within the same thirty-day period.

Acting Officers shall possess all authorities of the office except the power to make permanent appointments, veto resolutions, or initiate constitutional amendments. Any extension of an Acting Officer appointment beyond thirty(30) days shall require approval by majority vote of the Council of House Chancellors.

- (6) The term of office for the President, Vice President, and all High Council Secretaries shall be one (1) academic year, commencing upon assumption of office and concluding upon the assumption of their successors. No officer shall serve consecutive terms in the same position.

Section 3. The Office of the President

- (1) The President shall serve as the Chief Executive of the Society and the ultimate presiding authority of the High Council. The powers and duties of the President shall be:
 - (a) Serve as the primary head of the Society and its official representative in all external and university-level engagements;
 - (b) Preside over all sessions of the High Council, with the authority to determine the official agenda and order of business;



Republic of the Philippines
BENGUET STATE UNIVERSITY
La Trinidad, Benguet 2601

DEBATE SOCIETY



- (c) Serve as the Chairperson of the Supreme Council, exercising presiding authority over all administrative trials, disciplinary hearings, and constitutional interpretations of the Society;
- (d) Exercise the power to veto any society-wide resolution or policy passed by the Council of House Chancellors. A presidential veto shall render the proposed measure null and void unless challenged by the Council. The Council of House Chancellors may override a presidential veto only through a unanimous vote of all four (4) House Chancellors. Upon a unanimous override, the measure shall be enacted immediately as Society policy, and the President shall have no further power to block that specific resolution;
- (e) Spearhead the strategic execution of the Society's long-term objectives and mandates;
- (f) Ensure the rigorous enforcement of the Constitution, By-Laws, and High Council Resolutions across all jurisdictions and Houses of the Society.
- (g) The President shall have the sole authority to negotiate and enter into formal treaties, Memoranda of Agreement (MOA), and long-term alliances on behalf of the Society. Such agreements shall require the ratification of the Council of House Chancellors (COC) to be fully binding. All formal treaties, MOAs, or alliances negotiated by individual Houses with external institutions must be approved by the respective House Council and subsequently submitted to the President for final review. No House-level agreement with an external entity shall be valid or enforceable without the written approval and signature of the President. Such House-level approvals do not require the ratification of the COC, provided they do not affect other Houses or the Society as a whole;
- (h) The President shall appoint the Secretaries of the High Council and may create ad hoc (temporary) committees or commissions to investigate specific issues or execute special projects;
- (i) The President shall be mandated to deliver a formal State of the Society Address to the Assembly of the Society (AS) one (1) week after the conclusion of each semester. The President shall deliver a total of two (2) SOSAs throughout their one-year term. The address shall serve as the official report on the Society's financial health, departmental progress and the vision of the President, and the performance of the Four Houses;
- (j) In times of organizational crisis or extreme deadlock between Houses, the President may issue Executive Orders to ensure the continuity of Society



operations. Such orders shall be temporary and remain in effect until the High Council can convene to deliberate on a permanent solution;

- (k) The President shall exercise supreme oversight over the General Fund. While House Treasuries remain autonomous, the President must ensure that Society-wide funds are allocated in accordance with the pillars of the Society;

Section 4. The Office of the Vice President

- (1) The Vice President shall be the second-highest executive officer of the Society and the Chief Coordinator of its internal legislative affairs. The powers and duties of the Vice President shall be:
 - (a) Assume the full duties and presiding authority of the President in the event of their absence, temporary incapacity, or at the President's express request;
 - (b) Serve as the official presiding officer of the COC, responsible for convening sessions, managing legislative deliberations, and ensuring the Houses act in coordination;
 - (c) The Vice President shall not have a regular vote within the Council of House Chancellors except in the event of a deadlock (2-2 vote), in which case the Vice President shall cast the deciding vote;
 - (d) Monitor the internal affairs of the Four Houses to ensure their activities and policies remain consistent with the Society's Constitution and High Council resolutions;
 - (e) Spearhead the execution of Society-wide projects that require the joint participation of all Four Houses.

Section 5. The Office of the Executive Secretary

- (1) The Office of the Executive Secretary (OES) shall serve as the central administrative hub, archive, and secretariat of the Society. It shall be composed of the Secretary as the chief officer, the Assistant Secretary as the second-in-command of the office, Secretariat Officer(s), Secretariat Intern(s) as the President may authorize.
- (2) The powers and duties of the Office of the Executive Secretary shall include:
 - (a) Monitor the implementation of mandates and directives issued by the President across all Executive Offices, ensuring that all departmental actions are documented and aligned with Society standards;



Republic of the Philippines
BENGUET STATE UNIVERSITY
La Trinidad, Benguet 2601

DEBATE SOCIETY



- (b) Act as the sole guardian of the original copy of the Constitution, the Great Seal of the Society, and all historical archives, ensuring their absolute preservation and security;
- (c) Draft and maintain the formal minutes of all sessions of the High Council and the Supreme Council, providing the definitive and authenticated record of all Society actions;
- (d) Maintain the Book of Policies (BOP) to track the status of all policies passed by the Council of Chancellors, including those vetoed by the President or overridden by the Council;
- (e) Exercise the authority to certify official documents, membership statuses, and high-level communications. No act of the Society shall be considered official or enforceable without the attestation of the Office;
- (f) Spearhead the orientation and pillar education for all incoming Provisional Members, ensuring they are fully briefed on the Constitution and the Society's history before their deployment.

Section 6. The Office of Internal Affairs

- (1) The Office of Internal Affairs (OIA) shall be the primary department responsible for the welfare, ethical conduct, and internal cohesion of the Society. It shall be composed of the Secretary of Internal Affairs as the Chief Officer, the Assistant Secretary as the second-in-command, and such Internal Affairs Officers and Executive Interns as the President may authorize.
- (2) The powers and duties of the Office of Internal Affairs shall include:
 - (a) Maintain the comprehensive and secure registry of all Society members. This includes the authoritative tracking of an individual's progression from Executive Internship to Full Membership, alongside the verification of House affiliations and residency requirements;
 - (b) Design, propose, and spearhead the execution of Society-wide activities, events, and programs specifically aimed at enhancing the holistic well-being and inclusion of the membership. These programs may include mental health initiatives, member-retention socials, and skill-building retreats;
 - (c) Enforce the Society's Rules and Procedure. The Office shall have the mandate to investigate reports of misconduct, gather evidence, and recommend specific disciplinary actions to the Supreme Council;



Republic of the Philippines
BENGUET STATE UNIVERSITY
La Trinidad, Benguet 2601



DEBATE SOCIETY

- (d) Coordinate with the Executive Secretary to assign Executive Interns to their respective Executive Offices, ensuring a balanced distribution of manpower based on the Intern's skills and interests, and track their performance to ensure they meet the criteria for elevation to Full Member status;

Section 7. The Office of External Affairs

- (1) The Office of External Affairs (OEA) shall serve as the primary diplomatic and liaison arm of the Society. It shall be composed of the Secretary of External Affairs as the Chief Officer, the Assistant Secretary as the second-in-command, and such External Affairs Officers and Executive Interns as the President may authorize.
- (2) The powers and duties of the Office of External Affairs shall include:
 - (a) Serve as the primary bridge between the Society and external entities, including other academic institutions, government bodies, and the private sector;
 - (b) Spearhead the negotiation of formal partnerships, memoranda of agreement (MOA), and long-term alliances. The Office shall be responsible for vetting potential partners to ensure they align with the Society's Pillars;
 - (c) Design and execute strategies for the solicitation of external grants, corporate sponsorships, and donations to support Society-wide projects and the General Fund;
 - (d) Maintain and expand the Society's presence within national and international debating circuits, ensuring the Society is represented in major tournaments and summits;
 - (e) Spearhead, organize, and manage all events, programs, and activities of the Society that occur outside the organization or the university campus.

Section 8. The Office of Financial and Resource Affairs

- (1) The Office of Financial and Resource Affairs (OFRA) shall be the primary department responsible for the fiscal integrity, resource management, and logistical sustainability of the Society. It shall be composed of the Secretary of Finance as the Chief Officer, the Assistant Secretary as the second-in-command, and such Finance Officers and Executive Interns as the President may authorize.
- (2) The powers and duties of the Office of Financial and Resource Affairs shall include:



Republic of the Philippines
BENGUET STATE UNIVERSITY
La Trinidad, Benguet 2601

DEBATE SOCIETY



- (a) Exercise primary management over the General Fund, ensuring that all central funds are collected, recorded, and deposited in accordance with the High Council's financial standards;
- (b) Coordinate with all Executive Offices to draft the Annual General Budget. The Office shall review all funding requests before they are presented to the President, after the concurrence of the Council of Chancellors, for signature;
- (c) Maintain a comprehensive inventory of all Society-owned physical and digital assets. The Office shall be responsible for the procurement, maintenance, and storage of Society equipment;
- (d) Issue a Monthly Fiscal Report to the High Council and a comprehensive Annual Financial Statement to be included in the President's State of the Society Address (SOSA);
- (e) In coordination with the Office of Internal Affairs, the OFRA shall manage the collection of membership dues, tournament fees, and sponsorship funds, ensuring proper receipt and accounting.

Section 9. The Office of Business Affairs

- (1) The Office of Business Affairs (OBA) shall serve as the primary commercial and entrepreneurial arm of the Society. It shall be composed of the Secretary of Business Affairs as the Chief Officer, the Assistant Secretary as the second-in-command, and such Business Officers and Executive Interns as the President may authorize.
- (2) The powers and duties of the Office of Business Affairs shall include:
 - (a) Spearhead the development of income-generating projects, including the sale of Society merchandise, publication of paid journals, and the management of ticketed events or tournaments;
 - (b) In coordination with the Office of Public Affairs, manage the commercial brand of the Society to ensure that all business ventures maintain the prestige of the Pillars;
 - (c) In coordination with the Office of External Affairs, manage the commercial contracts with vendors, media partners, and technical service providers, ensuring the Society receives the best value for its investments;
 - (d) Research and implement modern funding models, including digital subscriptions, crowdfunding, and the commercialization of the Society's intellectual property;



- (e) Provide the High Council with long-term economic forecasts and sustainability plans to ensure the Society's financial independence from university-only funding.

Section 10. Office of Public Affairs

- (1) The Office of Public Affairs (OPA) shall serve as the primary media, communications, and public relations arm of the Society. It shall be composed of the Secretary of Public Affairs as the Chief Officer, the Assistant Secretary as the second-in-command, and such Public Affairs Officers and Executive Interns as the President may authorize.
- (2) The powers and duties of the Office of Public Affairs shall include:
 - (a) Manage the public image of the Society and serve as the primary press office. The OPA shall be responsible for drafting official press releases, managing media relations, and responding to public inquiries;
 - (b) Exercise sole authority over the Society's official social media platforms, websites, and digital archives, ensuring a consistent and elite aesthetic in all postings;
 - (c) Spearhead the creation of high-quality visual and audio content, including photography, graphic design, and video production;
 - (d) Manage, design, and maintain the Official Website of the BSU Debate Society. Maintain a public-facing repository of the Constitution, High Council Resolutions, as provided by the OES, and the Society's history. Develop and secure portals for membership applications. Optimize the website to ensure the Society's initiatives are accessible to a national and international audience;
 - (e) Maintain a visual record of all Society-wide events, ensuring that the history of the administration is documented through photography and film.

Article 9.

THE COUNCIL OF HOUSE CHANCELLORS

Section 1. Declaration of the Council of House Chancellors.

The Council of House Chancellors shall be the supreme legislative and representative body of the Society. It shall be composed of the House Chancellors of the Four Houses who serve as the primary custodians of their respective House legacies and the voices of their constituents within the High Council.



Section 2. General Provisions of the Council of House Chancellors

(1) The Council of House Chancellors shall serve as the supreme deliberative, regulatory, and policy-formulation chamber of the Society, except to the extent reserved to the people by the Constitutional provision on initiative and referendum. In the pursuit of Enlightenment and the defense of the Four Pillars, the Council shall exercise the following unified powers:

- (a) To author, deliberate upon, and enact the Blue Book, a comprehensive manual governing the Society's operational mechanics. This includes the codification of parliamentary procedures, the management of the House Point System, and the establishment of rigorous financial requisition protocols to ensure institutional transparency;
- (b) To establish and maintain the Red Book, translating the virtues of Leadership, Truth, Scholarship, and the Arts into a binding ethical framework for all members, and to amend such rules as necessary for the continuous benefit and evolution of the Society;
- (c) To draft the official position of the Society regarding pressing societal issues. A proposed stance requires the affirmative vote of three out of four House Chancellors and the concurrence of the President. Upon dual approval, the Society shall issue a formal statement, the publication and dissemination of which remains at the discretion of the President; provided that, in exercising such discretion, the issued statement shall clearly and faithfully represent the specific position adopted by the Society through the Council of House Chancellors;
- (d) To author and deliberate upon formal policy propositions that the Society intends to lobby to the Benguet State University Administration or the Local Government Unit (LGU). Such propositions require the final approval of the President before they are officially introduced to external bodies by the Office of External Affairs, acting upon the President's direction;

Section 3. Composition of the Council of House Chancellors.

(1) The Council of House Chancellors shall be a four-member deliberative body, representing the core pillars of the Society. The composition is as follows:



Republic of the Philippines
BENGUET STATE UNIVERSITY
La Trinidad, Benguet 2601

DEBATE SOCIETY



- (a) The Presiding Officer. The Vice President of the Society shall serve as the ex-officio Presiding Officer. The Vice President shall maintain order, facilitate the agenda, and certify all legislative acts. The Vice President shall have no vote except in the event of a tie.
- (b) The Council consists of one (1) Chancellor from each of the Four Houses, who serve as the primary representatives of their respective constituents: (i) Chancellor of House Bathala, (ii) Chancellor of House Laon, (iii) Chancellor of House Manama, (iv) Chancellor of House Kabunian.
- (c) The Council Secretary shall be appointed by the Vice President from among the various House Secretariat Directors to serve as the primary recording officer and custodian of the Council's legislative records.

Article 10.

THE HIGH TRIBUNAL

Section 1. Declaration of the High Tribunal

The judicial power of the Society shall be vested in the High Tribunal. It shall serve as the court of original and final jurisdiction for all cases involving the interpretation of this Constitution, grievances between Houses, and serious breaches of the Red Book.

Section 2. Composition of the High Tribunal

- (1) The High Tribunal shall be composed of the President, who shall serve as the Presiding Judge, and the four (4) House Chancellors, who shall serve as the Jury of the Pillars. The Executive Secretary of the High Council shall serve as the Secretary of the Tribunal, responsible for the intake and technical processing of all petitions. No case shall proceed to trial without a formal determination of sufficiency by the President.
- (2) Recusal Protocol for Point Disputes. In proceedings under Article I, Section 2(7) of the Rules and Procedures concerning House Point System disputes, the Chancellor of the House directly involved shall serve as Defense Chancellor per Section 3 and shall recuse themselves from voting. The "Jury of the Pillars" for such matters shall consist of the three uninvolved Chancellors, whose majority vote shall decide the point transaction. This protocol shall not apply to disciplinary or constitutional interpretation cases.



Republic of the Philippines
BENGUET STATE UNIVERSITY
La Trinidad, Benguet 2601

DEBATE SOCIETY



Section 3. In the pursuit of institutional justice, the Tribunal shall adopt a specialized adversarial mandate. The Chancellor of the House to which the respondent belongs is constitutionally bound to act as the Counsel for the Defense. Conversely, the remaining three Chancellors shall constitute the Commission on Prosecution, representing the standing of the Society and the sanctity of its laws.

Section 4. Upon the conclusion of the trial and after due deliberation with the Jury of the Pillars, the President, as the Presiding Judge, shall deliver the final verdict. The verdict must clearly state the findings of fact and the specific provisions of the Red Book or Constitution that were applied.

Section 5. Any party aggrieved by the verdict of the High Tribunal reserves the right to a singular appeal. In such instances, a Re-Trial shall be convened, presided over by the Society's Chief Adviser. The Adviser shall sit as the presiding authority to review the evidence and the law, and their decision in the appellate trial shall be final, executory, and beyond further challenge.

Article 11.

ELECTIONS AND VOTES

Section 1. Elections for all Society officers must be held at a general meeting and decided through a majority vote of active members, except for the Office of the President, which shall be elected exclusively through the Presidential Conclave as established in Article VII of the Rules and Procedures, composed solely of the four sitting House Chancellors.

Section 2. The electoral process may be subject to provisions determined from time to time by the Executive Committee, consistent with the constitution.

Article 12.

MEETINGS

Section 1. The society shall have general meetings at least once (1) a month and officers must have regular meetings once (1) a month.

Section 2. Special meetings shall be scheduled by the Executive chairperson as needed.



Republic of the Philippines
BENGUET STATE UNIVERSITY
La Trinidad, Benguet 2601

DEBATE SOCIETY



Section 3. The quorum shall be constituted of a majority of the officers and members. Only present members shall be allocated one (1) vote. All decisions approved during the meeting shall be final and executory.

Article 13.

AMENDMENT AND REVISION

Section 1. Any member and officer of the society may request for an amendment and/or a revision of the constitution and by-law, which will be subject to a deliberation among the officers.

Section 2. Any amendment or revision of this Constitution will be carried with a majority vote in a general meeting. Amendments to the Rules and Procedures may be ratified through the distinct classification and approval process established in Article IX of the Rules and Procedures, provided no amendment supersedes or contradicts this Constitution.

Article 14.

DEPENDABILITY AND SEPARABILITY CLAUSE

Section 1. The Debate Society constitution does not repeal the existing main constitution of the University.

Section 2. If any article in this constitution shall be held invalid, the other articles will not be affected and will remain in full effect.

Article 15.

EFFECTIVITY CLAUSE

Section 1. The constitution and by-laws will be effective after the ratification of members during a meeting called for the purpose.

Section 2. Publication of the constitution and by-laws shall be made available to all members upon request.